

Where does space begin?

Space badge

The American space agency NASA awards astronaut wings to service personnel and civilians who have flown more than 80 km (50 miles) above the Earth's surface. Shown here are civilian astronaut wings.

If you could drive a car straight up, it would take only about an hour to reach space.

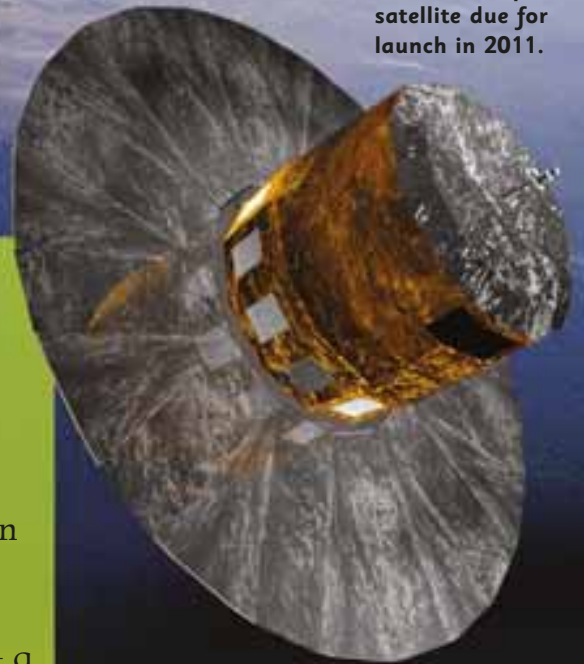
Gaia, a European satellite due for launch in 2011.



Slipping through air

A spacecraft has to be streamlined to move easily and safely through air. Where necessary, an extra part called a fairing is added to achieve this effect – a nose cone is a fairing.

The parts of a space shuttle (the orbiter, fuel tank, and rocket boosters) are streamlined for lift-off.



Space hat-ellite

Satellites can be any shape at all – even hat shaped. They don't need to be streamlined, because there's no air in space.